WORLD WAR II FIGHTER PILOTS

Being a fighter pilot was the most glamorous job in World War II. Young men in all combatant countries competed for a chance to fly the most advanced fighter aircraft in the world. Those few individuals who possessed the ideal combination of fast reaction times, sharp eyesight, and a killer instinct were able to have an exceptional impact on the air war. It has been estimated that the top five per cent of pilots were responsible for 40 per cent of kills. For this reason, the balance of air combat would turn decisively against any country forced by heavy losses to field too many inexperienced pilots. This is what happened to both the Germans and the Japanese in the later stages of the war – a blow from which neither country recovered.

US ESCORT FIGHTER PILOTS

The United States' B-17 and B-24 bombers were designed to attack in daylight without fighter escorts, and their speed, altitude, and firepower would supposedly make them immune to enemy fighters. But heavy losses in 1942-43 proved they needed fighter cover. At the outset, American fighter groups in Europe mostly flew Spitfires, which had inadequate range, or P-38 Lightnings, which had poor manoeuvrability. The Republic P-47 Thunderbolt was an improvement, but still it could not accompany bombers all the way into the heart of German territory. It was the arrival of the North American P-51 Mustang in early 1944 that transformed the situation. The Mustang could outperform any existing German fighter – its top speed was an impressive 700kph (435mph) – and with drop tanks it could fly anywhere that the bombers could reach.

US escort fighter pilots had the quality to match their machine. By 1944 many had lengthy combat experience, but intensive training sessions were still run to keep everyone at their peak. Some of America's most famous pilots flew escort in Mustangs, including future sound-barrier breaker Chuck Yeager, who shot down five German aircraft in a single day in October 1944. Like the bombers, the fighter groups flew mostly from bases in England and Italy. There was competition between different groups to be the safest for bombers to fly with. Especially keen was 332nd Fighter Group, all of whose pilots were black. These "Tuskegee airmen" had struggled long and hard against racial prejudice for the right to fly fighters in combat and they had plenty to prove.



P-51 Mustang
The Mustang is widely regarded as the supreme fighter aircraft of World War II. It combined an American airframe with a British Rolls Royce Merlin engine.

Escorting bombers against the toughest targets, including Berlin and the Ploesti oilfields, they claimed, perhaps with slight exaggeration, never to have lost a bomber under their protection. The Luftwaffe fighters adapted their tactics to meet the challenge of the Mustang. They hit the bombers with rapid mass attacks, hoping to disappear before the escort fighters could react. They also introduced the Me 262, the first jet fighter to enter combat, which was 160kph (100mph) faster than the Mustang. But nothing availed to stem their losses, especially after the Americans began roving away from the bomber streams to hunt down Luftwaffe fighters and attack their bases. By the end of the war, Mustang-equipped fighter groups had shot down some 5,000 German fighters, and destroyed over 4,000 on the ground.





Tuskegee airmen
The black pilots of the 332nd Fighter Group, trained at Tuskegee in Alabama, became African-American heroes.